

# Who Owns the Sidewalk? Informal Street Vending in Ho Chi Minh City through Sociological Theory

*Weekly Homework, Session 02 – Major Sociological Theory*

## 1. Introduction

On the sidewalks and in the alleyways of Ho Chi Minh City (HCMC), informal street vending is at once a livelihood, a public service and a target of municipal campaigns. Because it places economic survival, urban governance and the use of public space in direct contact, it is a useful case for testing sociological theory. This essay applies three perspectives from class: Structural Functionalism, Conflict Theory and Interactionism, with most weight on the first two. It argues that they answer different questions: Functionalism explains why vending persists and why some regulation is needed, Conflict Theory explains who bears the cost of that regulation, and Interactionism explains why the same street can be read as “disorder” or as “city life”.

## 2. Four Types of Research Questions

Following the definitions used in class, a factual question asks how or why things occur; a comparative question asks how things differ and why; a developmental question asks what can be improved and how it could be implemented; and a theoretical question asks which theories explain the factors involved and whether there is a gap between theory and reality. For street vending they can be posed as follows.

**Factual.** How does street vending currently operate in HCMC, and why do many rural-to-urban migrants, who often lack a local household registration (*hộ khẩu*), turn to it rather than to formal employment?

**Comparative.** How do enforcement and vendors’ income stability differ for mobile cart vendors in District 1 compared with peripheral working-class districts such as Bình Tân or District 12, and why? Keeping the vendor type constant makes location the main variable. A comparison over time (for example, before and after the 2016–2017 clearance campaign, or with the relative tolerance that followed Đổi Mới in 1986) would follow the same logic.

**Developmental.** What could improve the situation for both vendors and other street users, and how could it be implemented? For example, designated trading zones and hours negotiated with vendors, combined with basic hygiene support.

**Theoretical.** Which theories best explain the pattern of tolerance and clearance, and is there a gap between what the theories predict and what happens on the street? For instance, if regulation simply restored urban balance, we would not expect enforcement to vary so much between districts.

## 3. Structural Functionalism: Vending as Part of a Working System

Functionalism, associated with Durkheim and Parsons, sees society as a structure of interrelated parts, like organs serving the body as a whole. It distinguishes *manifest functions*, which are visible and intended, from *latent functions*, which are invisible and unintended, and it considers *dysfunction*, where a part stops serving its function and society restructures around alternatives

(Merton, 1968).

The manifest function of vending is plain: it supplies cheap, decentralised meals and everyday goods to factory workers, students and low-income households. A latent function concerns migrants. Durkheim's concept of *anomie* describes the strain felt when old norms no longer apply and new ones have not yet been absorbed, as for a villager arriving in a fast-growing city. Vending requires little capital and no formal hiring, so it absorbs people the formal labour market does not, and this may ease that strain. It is latent because neither vendors nor the city set out to create such a buffer; it is an unintended by-product of many individual survival decisions. The same accessibility keeps living costs lower for workers, though this overlaps with Marxist arguments about the cost of reproducing labour.

The dysfunction is that the sidewalk, planned as a space for pedestrian movement, no longer fully serves that purpose where it is occupied by stalls; congestion and food-safety risks add to this. Zoning, licensing and scheduled hours can then be read as the "restructuring" that Functionalism expects. In answer to the theoretical question, this perspective leans toward "administrative necessity".

**Limitation.** Functionalism tends to treat regulation as neutral. It cannot easily explain why enforcement is uneven across space or why vendors seldom shape the rules.

#### **4. Conflict Theory: Vending as a Struggle over Space**

Conflict Theory holds that social structures arise from struggle between groups with different interests and resources, and that power and resources are unequally distributed. Applied to cities, it draws on Lefebvre's (1968) idea of the "right to the city", developed by Harvey (2008) as a collective right to shape urban life. Sidewalks are a scarce resource valued differently by different groups: by vendors as a workplace, and by the state and investors as part of an image of a modern, attractive city that supports tourism and investment.

Read this way, clearance campaigns are not simply neutral traffic management. Kim (2015) shows that in HCMC, sidewalks are a contested site where ideas of modernity are pursued through the regulation of everyday street life. Vendors, who typically have limited political voice and few alternatives, bear the costs. The comparative question becomes significant here: if enforcement is consistently stricter in areas of high property value, that pattern would support a class-based interpretation, and it would be an example of a gap between the Functionalist prediction and reality. In answer to the theoretical question, this perspective leans toward "spatial exclusion".

**Limitation.** Conflict Theory can understate real problems, since congestion and food-safety risks affect other residents too, including low-income ones. It also risks portraying the state as a single actor, whereas local officials may negotiate or tolerate vending in practice (Turner & Schoenberger, 2012).

#### **5. Interactionism: How the Street Is Given Meaning**

Interactionism, founded by Mead (1934), holds that meaning is built through everyday interaction and that people act according to how they define situations. As class put it, planners

assign functions to space, but users create meanings through use. The same alley can therefore be defined by officials as an untidy obstruction and by customers and neighbours as a valued place to eat and socialise. Labelling matters too: vendors described as “illegal” may accept, resist or reinterpret that label, which is an empirical question of the kind labelling theory raises. This lens adds what the other two omit, namely how vendors and users themselves experience the space day to day, and it suggests that any developmental proposal should be tested against those meanings.

## 6. Synthesis and Position

The three perspectives work as diagnostic lenses: Functionalism asks whether the arrangement serves a real function; Conflict Theory asks whose interests it serves and who is excluded; Interactionism asks how people actually interpret the space. Functionalism accounts for the persistence of vending and the legitimacy of some regulation. On the evidence discussed here, Conflict Theory offers the stronger explanation of *how* campaigns operate, because it explains variation in enforcement and the exclusion of vendors from decisions. Interactionism explains why the conflict is also symbolic.

This points to a policy direction: regulation is more defensible when it includes vendors, for example through zones and hours negotiated with them, than when it only removes them. Street vending in HCMC therefore cannot be reduced to “disorder”. It reflects an ongoing tension between the city’s ambition to be an orderly global metropolis and its dependence on an informal economy. Answering the factual and comparative questions with real data would show which theory the evidence supports most strongly.

## References

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